1. Introduction

1.1 The Role of Mechanised Verge Maintenance

Road verges are cut because they are infrastructure. Vegetation left to grow closes sight lines at junctions and bends, obscures signs and barriers, blocks the drainage channels that keep water off the carriageway, and encroaches on the running surface itself. A national road network carries tens of thousands of kilometres of verge, and each kilometre is cut several times in a growing season, so the work is continuous, repetitive and performed almost entirely by machine.

It is also performed from a moving vehicle. Stopping to cut each section would require closing the lane, so a carrier drives the road at a few kilometres per hour while a boom-mounted mowing head works the verge alongside it. The head must hold a cut height of a few centimetres over ground that rises and falls continuously, follow a grass line that curves with the road, and do so without striking the surface hard enough to damage the tool or lift the machine.